

26/02/2026

Merrie Creek - Establishment Report

Property: Merrie Creek
Location: Merrie Creek Road, Clinton
Total Area: 277 ha
Planted Area: 188.5 ha
Elevation: 141 m - 364 m
Median Annual Rainfall: 850-950 mm

1. Property Description

Merrie Creek is located on Merrie Creek Road, Clinton. The total property area is 277 hectares, with 188.5 hectares established in plantation, with an existing 4.0 Hectare stand of Pinus Radiata planted in 2002 with the remainder planted in 2025. A title sub-division is in process removing around 70Ha from the existing title.

Elevation across the property ranges from 140 metres to 370 metres above sea level. The property receives an median rainfall of between 850-950 mm.

2. Land Preparation

To ensure maximum plantable area on this property land preparation on this property involved:

- Mechanical raking of mature gorse by Nick Wilson Contracting, around 15Ha was cleared.
- Formation of a network of access tracks throughout the property, these were constructed for planting contractors.
- Pre-plant aerial spraying of gorse areas at the following rates:
 - 7.5 L/ha Glyphosate
 - 1 L/ha Organo
 - 150 L/ha water

This ensured adequate vegetation control in selected areas prior to establishment of seedlings.

3. Pest Control

Recorded pest control operations commenced on **8 August 2025**. These operations were undertaken by contractors employed by the landowners.

Animals Controlled to Date:

Species	Numbers Eliminated
Deer	5
Possum	255
Hare	81
Rabbit	4
Total	315

Control operations are ongoing, with kill numbers recorded daily via a WhatsApp chat. Additional pest activity or damage observed during VFL pest surveys was reported to the pest controllers for follow-up action.

4. Forest Establishment

2025 planting was completed between **4-12 August 2025**.

- **Total Area Planted:** 184.5 ha
- **Total Seedlings Planted:** 194,300 *Pinus radiata*
- **Primary Contractor:** Proforest Services Limited

Seedling Supply:

- Appleton's (Nelson) - 84,900
- Arborgen (Nelson) 57,500
- Arborgen Southland (Edendale) 51,900

Stocking

Post-planting assessment conducted by VFL using **0.04 ha circular bounded plots**, with one plot representing approximately 3 hectares.

- **Average Stocking (VFL Plot Data):** 1,037 stems per hectare (SPH)

All Contractors submitted plot data to Venture Forestry throughout the season at a rate of 1 plot every 3 Hectares.

5. Releasing Operations

Aerial releasing was undertaken by **High Country Helicopters** between **12-25 October 2025**.

Application Rates:

- 18 L/ha Release KT (Terbuthylazine/Hexazinone)
- 0.5 L/ha Steed (Haloxypop)
- 150 L/ha water

6. 2025 Survival Survey

The survival survey was completed on **26 February 2026**.

Methodology:

- Unbounded plots
- Assess 5 seedlings across 5 rows then 5 seedlings along row with a total of 50 trees per plot.
- Preassigned plot locations
- Each plot represents approximately 3 hectares

Results:

- **Average Survival: 88%**
- **Lowest Survival: 26%** (southwest corner - root raked area)
- Primary cause of mortality in low-survival area: **animal browsing**

Overall, survival and early growth across the property are strong, with a small isolated area of damage primarily due to pest pressure.

Prepared By



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